Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**



› (Sitting) Adani with brother Rajesh and wife Priti; (standing from left) nephew Sagar, son Karan and nephew Pranav

the margins for imports declining, Adani decided to expand his export business and went public with his company, Adani Exports. While the young Gautam was a savvy exporter, he soon realised that the real value of a company lay in creating assets. It was then, in 1995, that the third big turning point unveiled itself when Keshubhai Patel, the then Gujarat chief minister, decided to push hard on developing the state's coastal region. It was around this time that global commodities trader Cargill wanted to source salt produced across the Kutch coastline and chose Mundra as the best possible location to develop a port (it had good draught, making it easy for big ships to dock there).

Cargill entered into a partnership with Adani Exports to build a jetty but subsequently reneged on the deal. Adani saw opportunity in the crisis. As a trader, he knew how profitable a port could be and applied for permission to convert the jetty into a full-fledged port. By 2001, he had won the rights to run the Mundra port for 30 years. That would be the biggest turning point of his life. If others dismissed Mundra as a vast marshy coastline in the wilderness, Adani saw it in the same light as Dhirubhai Ambani did Jamnagar in Gujarat—a port town that would be the platform to achieve his dreams. While Dhirubhai and his sons, Mukesh and

HIS WAY

Work, leisure, likes and more... how Gautam Adani leads his life

WORKAHOLIC: Adani works for 12 hours on most days. "I always tell people that when I am at work, I relax. Whenever I go on a holiday, I work too," he says

STRESS BUSTER: Plays a game of rummy with his wife Priti at least three to four times a week, even if he reaches home late. "She is always the winner. The card game helps me relax and spend some quality time with my wife."

PERSONALITY TRAIT: A positive thinker, does not get worked up by any adverse situation. Believes in destiny

MANAGEMENT STYLE: Empowers professionals to think as entrepreneurs and take own decisions. Stands by them even if things go wrong. Follows his gut feeling, and prefers logical and simple solutions over jargon

OTHER INTERESTS: Says he doesn't have many friends; so likes going solo when walking or exercising. Loves old Hindi songs by Mukesh and Kishore Kumar

ROLE MODEL: Dhirubhai Ambani, who he met only once but has read a lot about. Says he can relate to the difficulties Ambani faced during the 'licence raj'

FAVOURITE FOOD: Is a foodie and vegetarian. Loves Gujarati cuisine, but while travelling tries out local delicacies

FAVOURITE GETAWAY: Destinations that have great scenic beauty. Switzerland tops the list

HOW HE TRAVELS: Does not like to flaunt his wealth, although he owns four private jets for business travel and has a fleet of luxury cars. Prefers to go to office in a jet-black, bulletproof Toyota Alphard